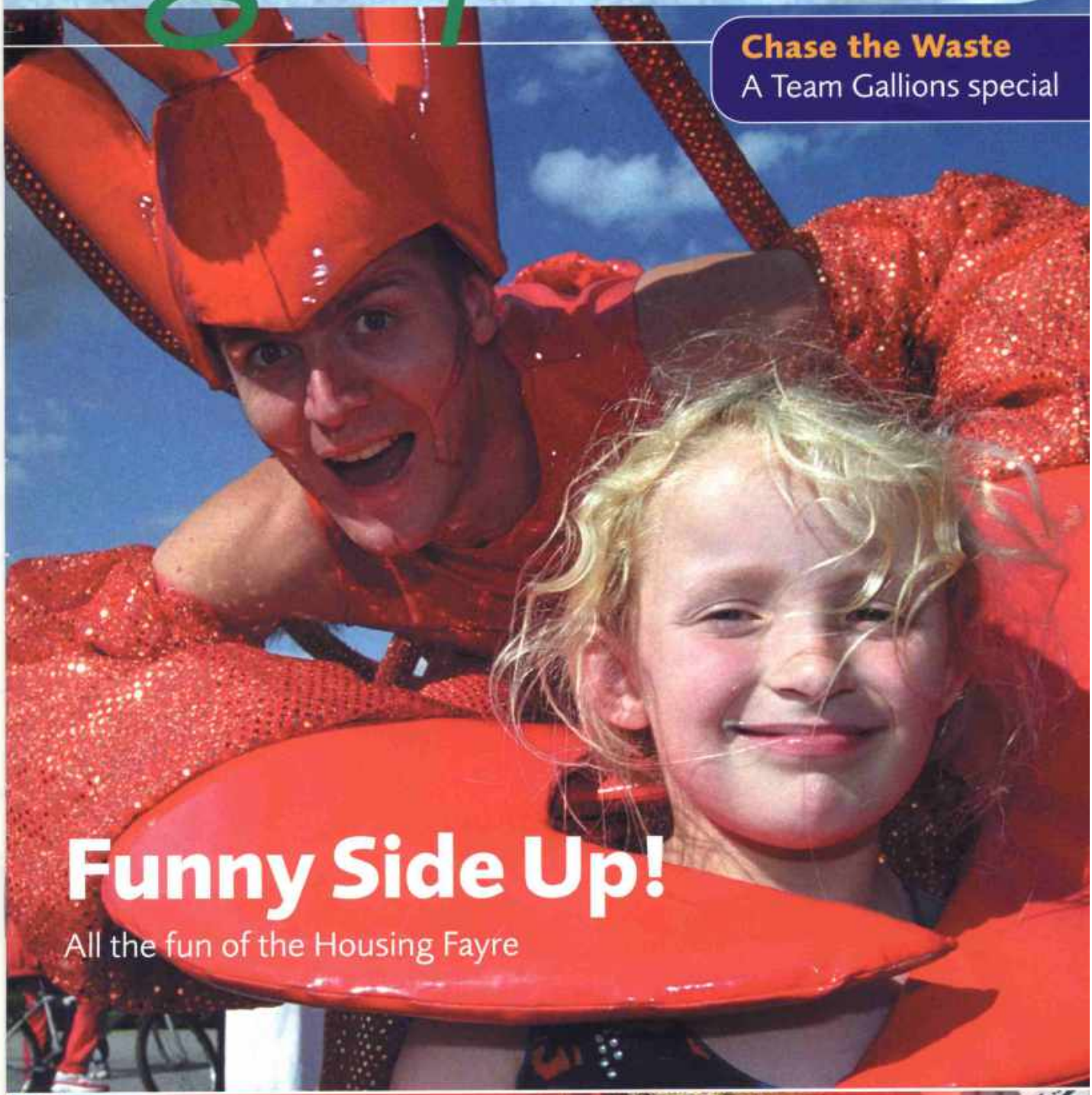
GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

ISSUE 13

Autumn 2003

grapevine

Chase the Waste
A Team Gallions special



Funny Side Up!

All the fun of the Housing Fayre



Cruise Control
The Neighbourhood Wardens get racey! Grapevine reports.

Bloomin Marvellous!
The winners of 'Thamesmead in Bloom' in all their glory.

On Yer Bike!
The police cyclists making Thamesmead a safer place to live.



Hot off the Press!

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Cubit Curbs Tax Dodgers

A recent Cubit roadblock in Harrow Manor Way caught out some of Bexley's worst tax-dodging drivers. In the two-hour crackdown, 25 vehicles were reported for no tax, nine cars were clamped, eight motorists were reported for not registering their vehicles and one was summoned for having no tax, MOT or insurance.

Problem Tenant Evicted

Gallions has obtained an Anti-Social Behaviour Order to ban a former tenant from returning to a block of flats at Whinchat Road, Thamesmead West.

The court heard substantial evidence from other tenants and residents about a long campaign of verbal abuse and threats. The judge took the extreme step of not only granting a possession order but also an Anti-Social Behaviour order against the Defendant, Mr. Leslie Williams, who was a tenant of Gallions.

New Key Worker Homes

At the beginning of August, Gallions was chosen to help spend some of the funding made available under the Starter Home Initiative. This aims to provide housing for key workers such as teachers, police, health workers and fire fighters. In all, Gallions has been allocated over £2.7m this financial year to help fund 63 one- and two-bed flats.

New Chair, New Start

Gallions is delighted to announce the appointment of Aman Dalvi as its new chair. Aman is currently Chief Executive of Gateway to London, an inward investment agency working to bring money into the Thames Gateway area. Before joining GTL he was Chief Executive of Ujima Housing Association. He has significant experience in strategic planning, developing political links with Local Authorities and Central Government, and attracting both public and private funds into organisations.

Loan Deal

In July Gallions completed a loan agreement with Barclays Bank to borrow £25m for a 30-year term. The loan was negotiated by Fred Angole, Director of Resources, with Devonshires Solicitors undertaking the related legal work. The money is required to finance plans to develop and regenerate Thamesmead.



Ye Haaaa! Chinese line dancers strut their stuff at the Atrium. The sessions are held 10-12am on Tuesday mornings. If you're interested call 020 8320 3414 for more information.

Ten Million for Tavy Bridge!

Gallions is set to receive ten million pounds in funding from the Office of the Deputy Prime Minister as part of the Communities Plan for the Thames Gateway. The money will be pumped into plans to redevelop the Tavy Bridge area of the Thamesmead estate, part of the original 1960s concrete stock. The project is Gallions' first phase of the long-term regeneration of the wider area.





Polished Performance
A major programme of floor polishing was undertaken by Team Gallions this summer to meet the service standards agreed with residents. During their spring programme, Team Gallions polished all the ground floor lift lobbies which had appropriate flooring, and 228 landings in the tower blocks were stripped and polished. The Team would like to thank all the residents who re-organised their day to avoid walking on floors until the polish had dried!

AXIS a Hit!
Gallions continues to work well with partnering contractor Axis to carry out tenant repairs. July's Customer Satisfaction figures for repairs reached 95%, and coincided with the completion of Axis' first year. Gallions recently asked its Customer Service staff to evaluate Axis and the response was very positive. Building Services and Axis are developing the service constantly and hope to provide an even better service year on year.

Stock Condition Survey
Building Services would like to thank everyone who took part in the Stock Condition Survey. Once all the information is collated and uploaded into their database, they'll be able to identify and plan future works for the next seven years to comply with the Decent Homes Standard.

Bend it
Like Bexley

Gallions is proud to sponsor the Bexley Business Academy's Girls' Football Team. With money from the Community Chest, the girls have been kitted out with a great new football strip. So good luck to them for the new league season!





Music Training Opportunities!

Thamesmead Youth Awareness Programme's Audio X course started again on 20 October. If you live in SE2, SE28 or DA18, you can achieve a London Open College Network certificate for the course. If you live in the wider Bexley and Greenwich Boroughs you can gain an in-house certificate of achievement.

Other opportunities at TYAP for 16-25s include steel drum lessons, street dance, DJ/MC lessons, use of a recording studio, drug awareness groups, personal development, Broadband Internet access and volunteering opportunities.

To find out more about any of the items listed above, or to book a taster session, contact Aminia on 020 8311 5111 or write to TYAP, c/o Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.



Wardens on the Road!

Remote controlled cars, bungee rides and computer games... it's all in a day's service for the Neighbourhood Wardens.

Driving Ambition

On Saturday 23rd August the Neighbourhood Wardens' Radio Controlled Car Club left the pits in Abbey Wood Park. 40 local young people took part in racing the radio-controlled cars provided by the Wardens, as part of their new community project aimed at involving young people in fun activities. The day was a fantastic success and more than ten races took place.

Greenwich Neighbourhood Renewal provided funding and some prizes for the day including unpainted Subaru body shells that can be attached to club cars for a more personalised racing experience! The track was made from perished Fire Hose supplied free by the London Fire Brigade Line and Hose department at Croydon Fire Station.

The event was free and it's now the intention of the Wardens to run the club in Abbey Wood and Thamesmead every fortnight, with league races and championships.

Birchmere Fun Day

The hottest day of the year didn't deter the Wardens from funding and staffing the Bungee Run and the Gladiator Joust inflatable games at the Birchmere Fun Day in August. Braving the hot weather, the Wardens kept the children occupied and content for the day whilst their parents soaked up the sun on the grass. Greenwich Volunteers (Abbey wood & Thamesmead Chapter), Gallions Housing Association, Thamesmead Police and the Army Cadet Force were among the agencies that attended the event.

Cyber Kids

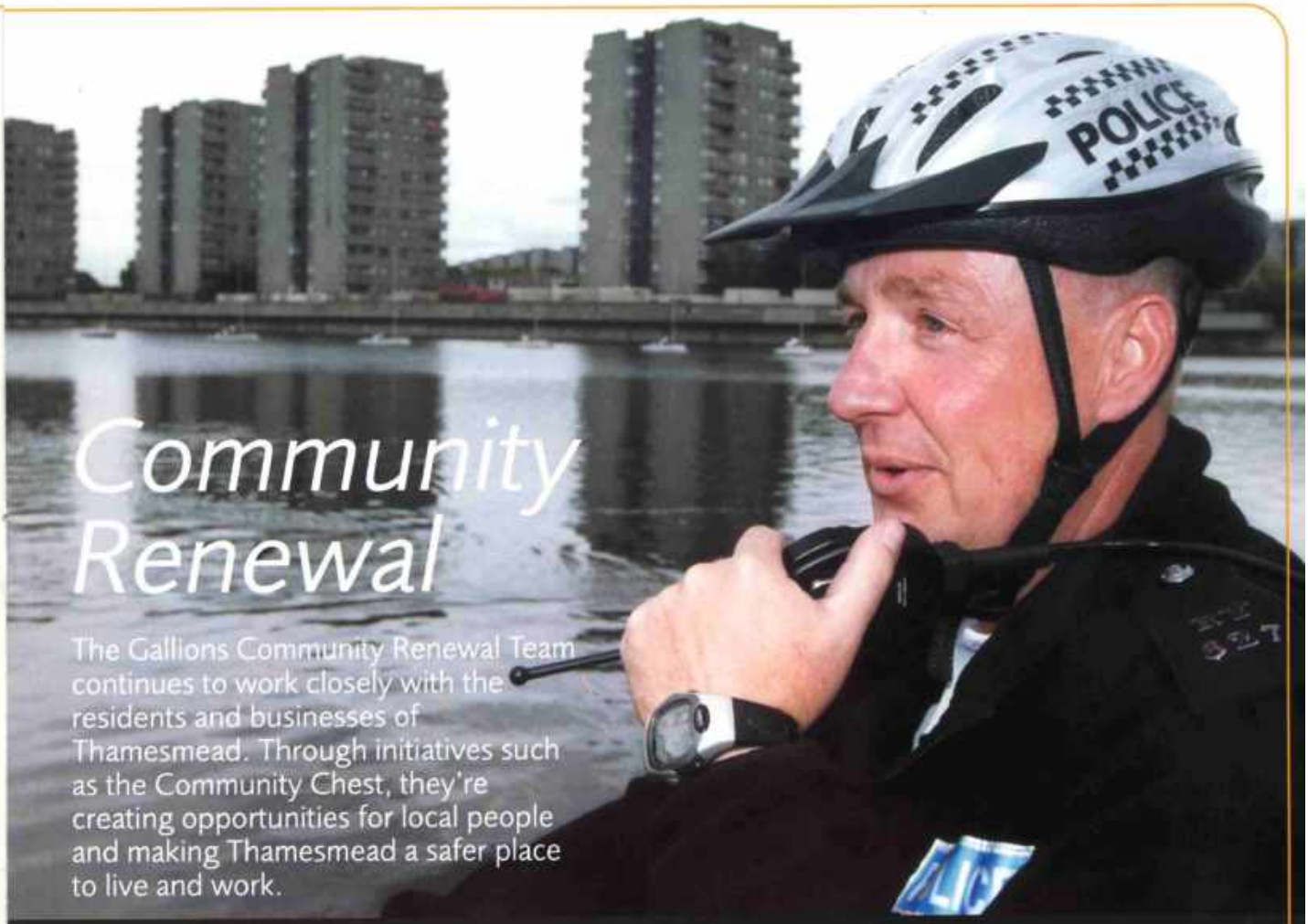
Last but not least, the Wardens turned their attention to cyberspace and started a Computer Games Club at the C2K Community Centre in Abbey Wood. The aim of the club was to provide activities for the local young people in a familiar and safe environment.

The children were kept busy with three Xboxes, three Playstation 2 consoles and one Game Cube. To get everything going, the Wardens purchased TVs, extra controllers and a number of games catering for various age groups.

The club was funded by the Gallions Residents Board and will eventually be based in a specific location in Thamesmead or Abbey Wood. Until a permanent home is found, the Wardens are taking the TVs, consoles, and games to various locations. Watch this space!



To get involved in these and other exciting activities visit the Warden website at: www.wardenweb.co.uk or call 020 8320 3441.



Community Renewal

The Gallions Community Renewal Team continues to work closely with the residents and businesses of Thamesmead. Through initiatives such as the Community Chest, they're creating opportunities for local people and making Thamesmead a safer place to live and work.

Bike Force

Residents should feel decidedly safer around Thamesmead from now on. The Gallions Community Renewal Team has just purchased two mountain bikes for the Police Homebeat Officers who patrol the Thamesmead East Ward.

Along with specially designed uniforms, the bikes were provided to help the Homebeat Officers patrol the area more effectively and ensure the best possible use of their time. The bikes help the Officers reach areas inaccessible by car and respond more quickly to incidents reported to them while they're on patrol.

When patrolling on the bikes, the police are able to increase the contact they have with members of the community, develop an understanding of issues affecting residents and help to tackle them.

The bikes have proved a big hit with officers Tim Lawlor and Rob Evans. PC Evans said: "Having use of the cycles to patrol Thamesmead has increased public awareness of policing in the area and enhanced the contact we have with the residents. We're very much committed to making Thamesmead a safer place by high profile patrolling, which we consider can be achieved by greater mobility through cycling".



In the Pipeline

Community Renewal has just won £5,000 to help support the Audio X programme (see the article opposite) by providing an extra member of staff to work in the drop-in centre. The Audio X scheme gives young people the chance to work with the latest music production software. So far, more than 45 people aged between 16 and 25 have used the project.

The Renewal team has also applied to Positive Activities for Young People to supply an outreach worker in West Thamesmead to engage young people through the innovative use of music. A bid to Carlton TV for an after-school club has also been successful, and the team has joined with St Margaret's Clitherow Primary school to work on this project. The club should be up and running by the end of October 2003.

All in all, there's plenty to look forward to.

Team Gallions
ENVIRONMENTAL SERVICES



waste watchers

Team Gallions receives lots of completed satisfaction survey forms each month, and they're showing that rubbish in the canals, dog mess and litter are still big issues with residents. Here are a few reminders of how you can help the Team eliminate these problems and make Thamesmead a cleaner place to live.

Car and away!

Unfortunately, people are still dumping unwanted cars around Thamesmead. If you want an unwanted car taken away, Team Gallions can do that for you free of charge. All you have to do is deliver the keys and log book to the reception at Harrow Manor Way. You'll also have to produce written evidence such as a driving licence to prove that you're the owner.



Bag it and Bin it!



Most dog owners have a responsible attitude and clean up after their dogs. However, to encourage the remaining owners who still don't appreciate the health hazards caused by dog waste, 50 new dog waste bins have been installed around the town. Free Scoop the Poop bags are also available from all Team Gallions vans and from Gallions' Harrow Manor Way offices.

Chute it down!

If you live in a tower block, please remember to use the chutes provided for your rubbish. Dealing with household rubbish is the job of the local Authority, not Team Gallions. For every member of Team Gallions that has to deal with household rubbish, there's one fewer member of staff available to clean windows, sweep staircases and deal with graffiti. So please use the chute or keep your rubbish in a dustbin and only put it out on the day the dustmen come.









A Bloom with a View

As well as dealing with rubbish, Team Gallions has found time to run a garden competition in Thamesmead. The revised Thamesmead in Bloom competition received an impressive 116 entries in four categories, and it was extremely hard to pick the winners. The first-place winners received their prizes from the Mayor of Greenwich, Councillor Janet Gillman, at the Housing Fayre in August. Here they are in all their glory:

Ms Nora Stewart:
Front garden, Leatherbottle Green

Mr and Mrs E. Hanion:
Back garden, Goldcrest Close

Mr. Peter Spencer:
Balcony, Binsey Walk.

Mrs Cowcher,
Window Box display, Mangold Way.

Each winner recieved £50 in B&Q tokens.

So well done to everyone who entered and good luck for next time!



Here comes

As well as all the serious stuff that keeps Gallions busy, we're always trying to provide fun activities for residents. We often organise fun days, and there have been some really great ones recently. So here's a run down of the fun that's been keeping everyone happy over the summer.

Annual Housing Fayre

Our sincere thanks to everyone who made our Annual Housing Fayre such an enjoyable and rewarding occasion. The day proved enormously successful with a variety of interesting activities for everyone to enjoy. John Austin MP officially opened the event, accompanied by the Mayor of Greenwich, Councillor Janet Gillman. The day was packed with exciting events and the air was filled with the sound of music and children's laughter all afternoon. The sun shone, the sky was blue and an assortment of brightly coloured flags fluttered gently outside the GHA offices to represent the many nationalities that make up the diverse community of Thamesmead.

There was something for everybody to enjoy, including face-painting, henna hand painting, bouncy castles and a football shootout competition. An excellent steel band, musical entertainment and a delightful exhibition of dance were provided by a highly talented group of youngsters from Thamesmead Youth Awareness Project. The Deputy Mayor of Bexley awarded certificates to all the dancers for their excellent performances.

Numerous stalls provided items of interest and give-away key rings, light bulbs and pens. The prizes won in a free prize draw included an audio system, video cassette, Sony TV and children's toys – to name just a few. Multicultural cuisine and BBQ food tempted the hungry, and ice creams were in constant demand.

We look forward to entertaining you all next year when we can do it all again!





s the Fun!

Eco Park Fun Day

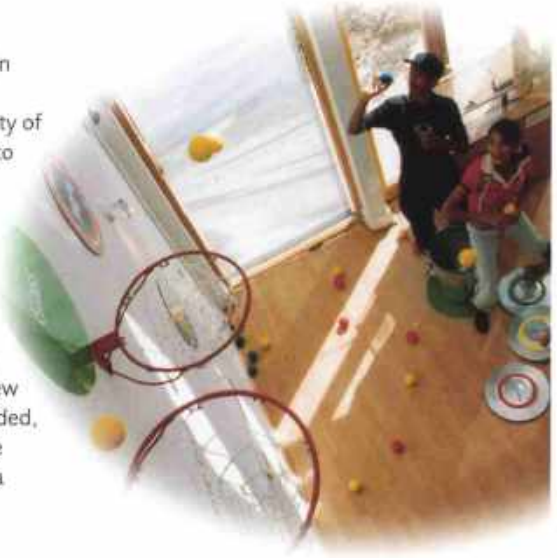
Eco-residents' day in the sun

The weather was perfect, the barbecue was sizzling and smiles abounded as the residents from the multi-award winning Ecopark celebrated during a community Fun Day.

Almost a year after residents moved into the development of environmentally sustainable houses, the neighbourhood event helped residents meet each other and learn about the innovative energy and water saving features included in the scheme.

The day was a joint venture between Gallions and the Ecopark Tenants' Association, and brought the majority of the residents out into the sunshine to take part in the celebrations.

Mandy Smith, Vice-Chairman of the Ecopark Tenants' Association said: 'It was a brilliant day and I think it did a lot to help build a sense of community spirit amongst the people who live here. Quite a few people said it was just what we needed, and to top it all we managed to raise almost £200 which will go towards a Christmas Party for the kids.'







Housing and Development Updates

Tavy Bridge Project

Throughout June, July and August the Tavy Bridge project team have been showing residents examples of what Tavy Bridge could look like after regeneration. Nearly half the residents who live at Tavy Bridge, Binsey Walk, Blewbury House and Tilehurst Point have visited the shop, filled out a questionnaire and given their opinions. This is fantastic news for the project team who have worked hard to encourage resident participation.

On 19 July the project team also held the second annual Tavy Bridge Fun Day. The day was a success with around 300 residents coming along to look at the design options and enjoy a variety of entertainments. Residents were asked to write down things they wanted to see changed, and have their photo taken holding up their comments.



Three residents' forums have now been held, giving people the chance to comment on whether they think Gallions is doing enough to consult the community over Tavy Bridge. They've also been asked to work with Gallions on the Residents' Charter and to discuss other projects that can address issues in the area. The final forum was very useful with many ideas being aired including more Neighbourhood Wardens, more amenities for young people, a large building suitable for a variety of activities and more jobs for local people.

Bexley's Lawn Scheme

A Fresh Start in a New Home!

Bexley Council recently introduced a new scheme called LAWN. The scheme is designed to help reduce waiting and transfer lists in London by offering people the opportunity to move to areas where there are surplus homes. Many of the properties on offer are spacious (often with gardens) and the rents are usually low in comparison with London. Most are in the North of the country or in Wales, but the list is growing all the time.

As well as a new home, the LAWN scheme also tries to help people with jobs and can offer help with removal and resettlement costs. Although the list is expanding all the time, at present the following areas are available through the scheme: Scotland, the Midlands and Yorkshire, the North East, the North West and Wales

Who can apply? As long, as you are a tenant with one of the Housing Associations operating within the Bexley Borough and are not in rent arrears, you can apply for the scheme. If you are interested and would like a registration form, please contact Koren Daniels on 020 8303 7777, extension 2557. Alternatively, you can email her on Koren.daniels@bexley.gov.uk.

Attention single people 18 or over who want accommodation in South Thamesmead!

We will be getting 13 self-contained bedsits in the Lesnes area of South Thamesmead.

If you have lived in the area for 12 months or more and would like to apply, please contact the rehousing team on 020 8320 3408/3405 stating that you are interested in BEDSITS.

Please note if you are interested in any other accommodation, there is currently a LONG waiting period.

Foreign nationals: if you have not got permanent residency of the UK, we are unable to accept your application.

NOTICE TO TRANSFER TENANTS!

Transfer tenants get a review form and letter every six months. If you do not return the form you will be removed from the transfer list. It is very important to return the form within the time stated on the accompanying letter.

Pay to Stay!

All you need to know about paying your rent or service charges.



Sadly, in recent months some Gallions' tenants have faced eviction because of non-payment of rent. Revenue Recovery is a dedicated team responsible for recovering arrears of rent and service charges. They also deal with all other rent and service charge enquires.

All tenancies with Gallions are weekly tenancies, with rent due each Monday. There are no exceptions to this rule. Some residents choose to pay monthly because that's how they receive their income. If you want to change to paying your rent monthly, please note that you will need to make payments in advance. This is to ensure that funds are available in your account to cover the rent due each Monday. If you are unable to do this you must speak to your revenue officer.

Calculating Monthly Rent

Mistakes are often made in calculating the correct amount of rent to pay. If you multiply your weekly rent by 4, this will only cover 48 weeks of the year and you will soon get into arrears. To calculate your correct monthly rent, take your weekly rent and divide by 7 (this will give you a daily rate). Then multiply by 365 (to give a yearly rate) and then divide by 12 (equal monthly payments for the year).

How to Pay

Direct Debits
More residents are now paying by direct debit because it makes life easier for them. Amounts are automatically changed when rent increases occur, without the need to fill in more forms. The Direct Debit Guarantee offers peace of mind.

Swipe Card
You can pay using your Swipe card at Post Offices, Banks and shops where you see the Allpay pay point sign. There are pay points all over the country so you can still pay your rent if you're working away or on holiday.

Standing Order
Payments are sent by your bank on specified dates or at regular intervals. This allows for weekly, fortnightly, four-weekly or monthly payments. Forms are available from Gallions Housing Association by calling free on 0800 838 481.

Post
Cheques can be sent direct to Gallions Housing Association Offices, Freepost SE6691, London SE2 9XH. We'd like to remind you that the Gallions' offices in Harrow Manor Way do not have the facilities to take cash payments, so please use your swipe card at an Allpay pay point instead.

If you have arrears and have not already discussed your situation with a member of staff, please do so now. We'll be fair and as flexible as possible. Our aim is to reduce your arrears, and if possible, avoid possession proceedings as this will increase your debt with the association.

Important Note
Our Welfare Benefit Officer (WBO) may be able to help you increase your income. He can check that you are receiving all the benefits you are entitled to and even assist with your initial application. So far this financial year, the WBO has been able to secure almost £50,000 in a variety of benefits for residents.

REWARDS FOR PAYING YOUR RENT!
Many organisations have 'incentive schemes'. For example supermarkets have loyalty cards and some utility companies give discounts to customers who pay by direct debit.
Gallions wants to explore the possibility of introducing a scheme to reward residents who pay their rent on time and keep their account clear. We'd like to ask if you would fill out the attached questionnaire sheet and return it to us (no need for a stamp) at: Freepost SE6691 London SE28 9BR or email your replies to revenue@gallionsha.co.uk.

Revenue Corner

Each month a Welfare Benefits Officer from the Recovery Department will be answering some tenant queries. So if you have a problem, please send it in and let them help solve your problems.

The tenant said:
Until 6 months ago, I was a self-employed cab driver. I had to give up work because I have been a heavy smoker since I was a teenager, and I now have chronic bronchitis and emphysema. I cannot claim incapacity benefit because my national insurance contributions were not kept up to date. My wife works as a school classroom assistant.
I owe £950 in rent and I am also overdrawn at the bank.

The WBO advises:
If you have multiple debts, I think you should consult a specialist debt advisor. I recommend you go either to Meridian Money Advice in Greenwich, or to the Citizens Advice Bureau Debt unit in Deptford. Do not use any of the commercial firms who offer to take on your debts for you. They will charge a fee and so effectively increase your debts. The CAB and Meridian Money Advice are free.
You should also claim Housing Benefit from your local Council, and if your medical condition is either permanent, or likely to last for at least six months (as is almost certainly the case with emphysema) you may be able to get Disability Living Allowance (DLA). If you get DLA, you may also get more housing benefit. The DLA claim form is a difficult form to complete, but your WBO can help you with it.

Call the Gallions free phone number for more information or to make an appointment with your WBO on 0800 83 84 81.

Board information

AGM

A number of guests were invited to help Gallions celebrate its third successful year by attending its Annual General Meeting on 24 September. Various appointments were made to the Board, which now comprises:

Independents	Residents	Local Authority Nominees
Ronke Adeagbo	Tokky Ademoyero	Manny Blake (Bexley)
Aman Dalvi (Chair)	Graham Horton (Deputy Chair)	Pete Challis (Greenwich)
Peter Dean	Freda McEwen	
Chris Garlick	Ken Sealey	
Keith Wrate		

Board Meeting Date

The next Board meeting will be held on 11 December 2003 at 7:00 pm at the Harrow Manor Way offices. All meetings are open to residents and if you are interested in attending please let Averyl Richards know on 020 8320 3410 or email her at arichards@galliionsha.co.uk

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

Customer Response Centre Freephone
0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls.

The old switchboard number will be withdrawn in the coming months.

Feedback

We welcome your suggestions and comments on how we can improve our services and make your environment and home a better place to live in. Simply send your comments to:-

Feedback, Gallions Grapevine, Caroline Wilson, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Don't forget to add your name, address and telephone number for contact details or alternatively email me on cwilson@gallionsha.co.uk

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phong bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Caroline Wilson (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

News for the over-60s

Contact the Elderly – puts a smile back into Sunday

Contact the Elderly is a charity that aims to relieve loneliness amongst older people.

It operates by creating small groups of volunteer drivers and hosts who organise group outings for Sunday tea once a month.

The charity offers companionship to over 2,000 isolated elderly people. These get-togethers minimise the feeling that no one cares and are full of laughter and friendship in the welcoming homes of caring volunteers.

This service is ideal for elderly people who have become isolated, have very little family assistance, and who probably can't get out much.

If you would like to know more about this FREE service, or want to learn about volunteering, please call free on 0800 716543 or visit www.contact-the-elderly.org

Pension Credit Launch Event

Pension Credit is a new entitlement that will be introduced from 6 October 2003. It replaces Minimum Income Guarantee and guarantees everyone aged 60 and over an income of at least £102.10 a week if you're single, and £155.80 for couples.

If you would like to know more about the introduction of Pension Credit, please come to the Pick It Up, It's Yours Pension Credit Launch event at Thamesmead Leisure Centre on Monday 3 November between 10am and 2pm. For more information on the launch please call 020 8218 4846.

Are you over Sixty?

Are you claiming your Winter Fuel Payment? A Winter Fuel Payment is a one-off payment to help older people with their winter heating bills.

For more information about Winter Fuel Payments, to tell us about a change of circumstances or to get a claim form for either this winter or past winters, ring the Winter Fuel Payment Help Line on 0845 9 15 15 15 (0845 601 5613 for textphone users). Lines are open Monday to Friday from 8.30am to 4.30pm and calls are charged at local rates.